how bored he was with the bourgeois civil servants and obsequious Indian rajahs he was forced to mix with. Too diffident for politics in England, and a bad public speaker, he took the job of governor general as it was the best administrative job available for him, though he knew or cared little for Indian history or civilisation, and on arrival did remarkably little to illuminate himself about either.

Reliance on his staff had made him popular at the Admiralty, his previous job, but it proved disastrous when he moved to India. Here, sent to rule a world of which he was completely ignorant, he quickly fell into the hands of a group of bright but inexperienced and hawkishly Russophobic advisers led by William Macnaghten – the man who had covertly supported Shah Shuja's 1834 expedition – and his two private secretaries Henry Torrens and John Colvin. As one of the members of his council, Thoby Prinsep, put it, 'Auckland was a good man of business, an assiduous reader of all papers, and very correct and careful in any of the drafts he approved and passed; but he was much wanting in promptness of decision, and had an overweening dread of responsibility which caused the instructions he gave to be so unsatisfactory that his agents had generally to decide for themselves what to do in any difficulty.' Prinsep added, 'He was considered to have yielded too much to his Private Secretary, John Colvin, who on occasions when the Governor General called his Members of Council into private consultation with himself, would take the whole initiative of discussion while his Lordship sat listening with his hands at the back of his head; and having thus so much thrown upon him he got the nickname of Lord Colvin among the younger Civil Servants.'[61]

On his leisurely journey 'Up the Country', Auckland was to be accompanied by his two waspish but adoring unmarried sisters, Emily and Fanny Eden, his pompous and pernickety Political Secretary, Macnaghten, and various other viceregal officials, attachés, wives and babies as well as Macnaghten's notoriously bossy and demanding wife, Frances, and her entourage of a Persian cat, a rosy parakeet and five attending ayahs.

The morning of departure dawned clear and fresh, and the Macnaghtens' friend Thomas Babington Macaulay got up early to come to see them off. Emily Eden noted in her diary – later to become one of the most celebrated travel accounts of the period – that the staff had laid on a 'very pretty procession . . . two lines of troops led from the door of Government House to the River'.[62] Only later that evening did she note the startling extent of